

The study and practice of many facets of maps and map making is called Cartography. It can be described as the art and science of map making.

Components of a map

The basic components of a map are the 1. Title 2. Scale. 3.Legend or key. 4. Direction 5. Source 6.Map projection and locational information and 7.Coventional signs and symbols

a. Title

Title tells about the content of the map and is placed mostly at the top corner or at the bottom corner of the map

b. Scale

The scale is a ratio between the actual distance on the ground and the distance shown on the map. Generally the cartographers cannot draw maps the same size as the land. So, they reduce the size of land or features proportionally. For this purpose maps are drawn to scale. Each map has its own scale, which is indicated on the map. Often the scale is shown with a scale bar or a line and number and is placed just below the title or somewhere at the bottom of the map.

To show large areas like continents or countries small scale maps are used. Small scale maps can show only major features omitting the minor ones due to lack of space .For example physical map of the world will show us only the major physical features in the world. It represents more area of the earth but gives us less information.

To show a small area like a taluk or district large scale maps are used.

The large scale maps portray the information in detail than the small scale maps. For example physical map of India represents a small area of the earth but gives us more information. However, there is no criteria for the classification of maps based on scale. It is only a comparative term.

ACTIVITY

Compare and find out the physical features of India which are omitted in the physical map of the world

Scales on maps can be represented in three different ways. They are:

1. Statement or Verbal scale
2. Representative Fraction (RF) or Ratio Scale
3. Graphical or Bar Scale

1. Statement or Verbal scale

In this method, the map scale is stated in words i.e., 1cm to 1 km. It means 1cm distance on the map corresponds to 1 km distance on the ground. Thus it is written on the map like 1cm to 1 km, 1 inch to 1 mile etc.

Simple statement scale has the following characteristics.

a. If the numerator is in centimeter, the denominator is either in meters or kilometers

b. If the numerator is in inch, the denominator is in miles

2. Representative Fraction (RF) or Numerical Fraction or Ratio Scale

It shows the relationship between the map distance and the corresponding ground distance in the same units of length. R.F. is generally shown as a fraction.

For example, a fraction of 1: 50,000 shows that one unit of length on the map represents 50,000 of the same units on the ground i.e., 1cm or 1 inch on the map represents 50,000 cm or 50,000 inches respectively on the ground.

RF is represented as 1/ 50,000 or 1: 50,000

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